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Acceptance & Commitment Therapy (ACT): Skills Guide

Psychological Flexibility, Mindfulness & Values-Based Living for Adults, Teens, Families & Practitioners



Flexibility

Open up. Be present. Do what matters.

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WHAT IS ACT?



What Is ACT?

Acceptance and Commitment Therapy (said like the word "act") is an evidence-based therapy that helps people make room for hard thoughts and feelings, and can spend their energy on what truly matters to them. ACT does not try to get rid of anxiety, sadness, or painful memories. It helps you change your relationship with them.

The Big Goal: Psychological Flexibility

Being able to notice what is happening inside you, stay in the present moment, and choose actions that line up with your values, even when uncomfortable feelings come along for the ride.

(adapted from Harris, ACT Made Simple)

The ACT Motto

Accept your thoughts and feelings and be present. Choose a valued direction. Take action.

Why Fighting Feelings Backfires

Most of us try to avoid, push away, or numb uncomfortable feelings. It works in the short term, but over time the avoided things get bigger, and life gets smaller. skipped classes or meetings, cancelled plans, avoided conversations, more screen-time escape, less of what we love. ACT calls this *experiential avoidance.* The more we struggle, the more stuck we get, like quicskand.

Metaphor: Tug of War with a Monster

Picture yourself pulling a rope against an anxiety monster, with a pit between you. You pull harder, it pulls harder. What if you simply dropped the rope? The monster is still there, but your hands are free to do something that matters. (Hayes et al., 2012; as described in Bethay, Weinstein & Stubbs, *ACT Strategies Guide*)

Who ACT Helps

Anxiety & worry Trauma-related struggles OCD (alongside ERP) Depression Stress & burnout
Chronic pain Perfectionism School avoidance Work stress Relationship conflict Parenting stress
Health challenges

For Adults

Whether it is a demanding job, a strained relationship, parenting, or a health diagnosis, ACT helps you stop waiting to feel better before you live better.

For Teens

You do not have to feel ready, confident, or calm to do things that matter. ACT helps you carry the hard stuff and still show up for your friends, goals, and future.

For Parents

Your child's feelings are not problems to fix. Validating, modeling openness, and cheering on values-based steps helps more than rescuing them from discomfort.

The ACT Hexaflex

ACT is built on six core processes that work together like the sides of a hexagon. They are not steps in a strict order; every one connects to every other, and strengthening one strengthens the whole. (Model: Hayes, Strosahl & Wilson)



Open Up Be Present Do What Matters

Acceptance + Defusion

Make room for feelings; unhook from thoughts.

Open Up Be Present Do What Matters

Present Moment + Self-as-Context

Notice what is here, from a steady observing place.

Open Up Be Present Do What Matters

Values + Committed Action

Choose a direction and take steps toward it.

Acceptance: Open Up

Acceptance means making room for uncomfortable feelings, sensations, and urges, instead of fighting them or running from them.



What it means

Acceptance is not giving up, liking the feeling, or approving of a bad situation. It is willingness: "I don't like this feeling, and I can let it be here while I do what matters." Feelings are like waves: they rise, peak, and pass on their own when we stop feeding the struggle.

Skills & Exercises

1 **Notice, Name, Make Room** (adapted from Harris, ACT Made Simple)

1. Notice where the feeling lives in your body (chest, throat, stomach).
2. Name it kindly: "Here is anxiety."
3. Breathe into and around it, as if making space.
4. Allow it to be there; you do not have to like it.

2 **Emotion Watching** (adapted from Bethay et al., ACT Strategies Guide)

1. Sit comfortably and pick a mild feeling to observe.
2. Describe it like a scientist: size, shape, color, temperature, movement.
3. Rate intensity 0–10 each minute.
4. Notice how it shifts when you watch instead of fight.

3 **Leaning Into Anxiety** (adapted from Bethay et al.)

1. Instead of tensing away, gently turn toward the sensation.
2. Say: "I'm willing to feel this for the next 60 seconds."
3. Soften the muscles around it.
4. Notice that you are bigger than the feeling.

4 Expansion Breath

1. Breathe in slowly for 4.
2. Imagine the breath flowing around the feeling.
3. Breathe out for 6, letting the body loosen.
4. Repeat 5 times.

5 Willingness Dial

1. Picture a dial from 0 (not willing) to 10 (fully willing).
2. Before a hard task, check your dial.
3. Ask: "Could I turn it up just one notch?"



Practice Ideas

- Practice 5 minutes of Notice-Name-Make Room daily.
- Use the Willingness Dial before a feared task.
- Keep a "waves" log: when a feeling rose and fell.

For Adults

Before a hard conversation with your partner or boss, or a medical appointment, try: "I'm willing to feel nervous and still show up."

For Families

Try "I can see this is really hard, and I believe you can handle it" instead of rushing to fix it. Model naming your own feelings out loud.

Defusion: Unhook From Thoughts



Defusion means stepping back from thoughts so you can see them for what they are: words and pictures in your mind, not orders or facts.

What it means

When we are fused, thoughts feel like the absolute truth ("I'm going to fail"). When we defuse, we notice the thought ("I'm having the thought that I'm going to fail"). The thought may stay, but it loses its grip, and we get to choose what to do.

Skills & Exercises

1 "I'm Having the Thought That..." (Hayes et al., Harris)

1. Catch a sticky thought: "I'm stupid."
2. Add: "I'm having the thought that I'm stupid."
3. Then: "I notice I'm having the thought that..."
4. Notice the extra distance each step creates.

2 Leaves on a Stream (Hayes et al., 1999; in Harris & Bethay et al.)

1. Imagine sitting beside a gentle stream with leaves floating by.
2. Place each thought on a leaf and watch it drift away.
3. If you get hooked, gently notice and return.
4. Practice for 5 minutes.

3 Name the Story

1. Notice your mind's favorite theme ("Not good enough").
2. Give it a title: "Ah, the 'Not Good Enough' story."
3. When it shows up, just name it and move on.

4 Silly Voices & Singing

1. Say the thought in a cartoon voice, or sing it to "Happy Birthday."
2. Notice the words are the same but the power changes.
3. (Use kindly, never to mock real pain.)

5 Thank Your Mind

1. When your mind warns or criticizes, say: "Thanks, mind!"
2. Recognize it is trying to protect you.
3. Then choose your next action.



Practice Ideas

- Write thoughts on sticky notes and look at them from arm's length.
- Do Leaves on a Stream before bed.
- Count how many times a day "the story" shows up.

For Adults

Work stress loves stories like "I'm failing at everything." Name it ("the Failure story"), thank your mind, and return to the next task.

For Families

Avoid arguing with your teen's thoughts. Try: "Sounds like your mind is telling you that. What would you do if that thought were just background noise?"

Present Moment: Be Here Now



Present-moment awareness means paying attention, on purpose and with curiosity, to what is happening right now, instead of being lost in worries about the future or replays of the past.

What it means

Our minds are time travelers. Anxiety lives in the future and regret lives in the past. Coming back to the here-and-now gives us access to what is actually happening and what we can do about it. It also helps us notice life's good moments.

Skills & Exercises

1 Drop Anchor (adapted from Harris, ACT Made Simple)

1. Acknowledge thoughts and feelings: "I notice anxiety."
2. Come back into your body: press feet into the floor, stretch, sit up.
3. Engage with the world: notice what you see, hear, and are doing.
4. Repeat the cycle 3-4 times.

2 5-4-3-2-1 Senses

1. Name 5 things you see, 4 you can touch, 3 you hear,
2. 2 you smell, and 1 you taste.
3. Say them slowly and with curiosity.

3 Mindful Activity (in Bethay et al.)

1. Pick a daily task: brushing teeth, eating, a shower.
2. Give it your full attention: sensations, sounds, smells.
3. When the mind wanders, notice and come back.

4 Being in the Now

(adapted from Bethay et al.)

1. Pause and ask: "Where am I? What am I doing?"
2. Notice your breath for three cycles.
3. Choose one thing to focus on fully.



5 Mindful Breathing (1 Minute)

1. Breathe naturally and follow the breath in and out.
2. Count breaths to 10, then start over.
3. Lost count? Just start again; that is the practice.

Practice Ideas

- Set 3 phone reminders a day: "Drop anchor."
- Eat one snack mindfully each day.
- Take a "noticing walk" with no phone.

For Adults

Drop Anchor between meetings, before walking in the door after work, or while sitting with a child or partner, fully there.

For Families

Practice mindful moments together: a device-free dinner, a noticing walk, or Drop Anchor during a tough moment in the car.

Self-as-Context: The Observing Self



Self-as-Context is the part of you that notices everything: thoughts, feelings, memories, and roles. It is always there and never harmed by what passes through it.

What it means

We have a "thinking self" full of stories and labels ("I'm the anxious one"), and an "observing self" that simply notices. You are not your thoughts or feelings; you are the space in which they show up. This helps us loosen rigid labels and feel steady during storms.

Skills & Exercises

1 The Sky & the Weather

(common ACT metaphor; see Harris)

1. Imagine you are the sky; thoughts and feelings are the weather.
2. Storms, clouds, and sunshine come and go.
3. The sky is never damaged by the weather.
4. Ask: "What weather is passing through right now?"

2 Noticing You're Noticing

(adapted from Harris)

1. Notice a sound... and notice that you are noticing.
2. Notice a thought... and the part of you that sees it.
3. Rest in that noticing part for 30 seconds.

3 Chessboard

(Hayes et al.)

1. Picture thoughts and feelings as chess pieces battling.
2. You are not the pieces; you are the board that holds them.
3. The board can hold every piece without joining the fight.

4 More Than a Label

1. Write a label you give yourself ("I'm lazy").
2. List 5 other things that are also true about you.
3. Notice you are bigger than any one story.

5 The Continuous You

1. Recall a memory from when you were small.
2. Notice the "you" who was there then is the same you noticing now.
3. That observing self has carried you through everything.



Practice Ideas

Draw yourself as the sky with today's weather.

Journal: "Today I noticed..."

Use the chessboard image during a conflict.

For Adults

You are more than your roles (employee, parent, patient). Notice the steady you underneath them on hard days.

For Families

Separate the child from the struggle: "You are having a hard time," not "You are a problem." Remind them who they are beyond anxiety.

Values: Know What Matters



Values are your heart's deepest desires for how you want to treat yourself, others, and the world. They are like a compass: they give direction but are never "finished."

What it means

Values are different from goals. A goal can be checked off ("make the team" or "get the promotion"); a value is ongoing ("being a supportive teammate or colleague"). Values are chosen, not imposed by parents, friends, or social media. Pain often points to what we care about: we hurt where we care.

Skills & Exercises

1 Values Card Sort

1. Read a list of values (kindness, courage, creativity, honesty, fun...).
2. Sort into Very Important / Important / Not Important.
3. Pick your top 5 and write what each means to you.

2 The Bull's-Eye (Lundgren; Harris, ACT Made Simple)

1. Choose a life area (see worksheet).
2. Write what matters to you there.
3. Mark how close your actions are to the center.
4. Pick one step to move closer.

3 Sweet Spot / Best Moment

1. Recall a moment you felt truly alive or proud.
2. Notice what you were doing and who you were being.
3. Name the values that were present.

4 Your 80th Birthday

1. Imagine a loved one speaking at your 80th birthday.
2. What would you want them to say you stood for?
3. Those words point to your values.

5 Hurt Points to Heart

1. Name something that hurts right now.
2. Ask: "What does this pain show me I care about?"
3. Write the value hidden underneath.



Practice Ideas

- Post your top 3 values somewhere visible.
- Each night: "One way I lived my values today..."
- Talk about values at family dinner.

For Adults

Check values across work, partnership, parenting, and health. Burnout often means living by others' rules, not your values.

For Families

Share your own values and notice your child's values in action: "That was really brave and kind." Let them choose values that are theirs.

Committed Action: Do What It Takes



Committed action means taking real, concrete steps guided by your values, even when it is uncomfortable, and getting back on track when you slip.

What it means

Values without action are wishes. Committed action turns values into habits, one small step at a time. Setbacks are expected; the skill is noticing you drifted and recommitting, again and again. Hard feelings are invited along for the ride; they do not get to drive.

Skills & Exercises

1 SMART Values Goals (adapted from Harris)

1. Specific: what exactly will you do?
2. Meaningful: which value does it serve?
3. Adaptive: is it likely to improve life?
4. Realistic and Time-framed: when, and how much?

2 Passengers on the Bus (Hayes et al., 2012; in Bethay et al.)

1. You are the bus driver; thoughts and feelings are passengers.
2. Some shout scary things to make you turn around.
3. You can let them ride and keep driving toward your values.

3 Tiny Steps Ladder

1. Pick a valued goal that feels big.
2. Break it into 5–8 small steps, easiest first.
3. Do one step this week, even with discomfort.

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4 Expect Barriers (FEAR → DARE) (Harris)

1. Name barriers: Fusion, Excessive goals, Avoidance, Remoteness from values.
2. Answer with DARE: Defusion, Acceptance, Realistic goals, Embracing values.
3. Plan your response ahead of time.

5 Recommit Without Shame

1. Notice a slip with kindness: "I got off track."
2. Reconnect with the value: "Why does this matter?"
3. Choose the very next small step.

Practice Ideas

Use the Committed Action Plan worksheet weekly.

Tell a supportive person your one step.

Celebrate effort, not outcome.

For Adults

Pick one step:

a 10-minute walk for health, a phone-free hour with family, or voicing a need at work, then schedule it.

For Families

Praise willingness and effort ("You went even though you were nervous!").

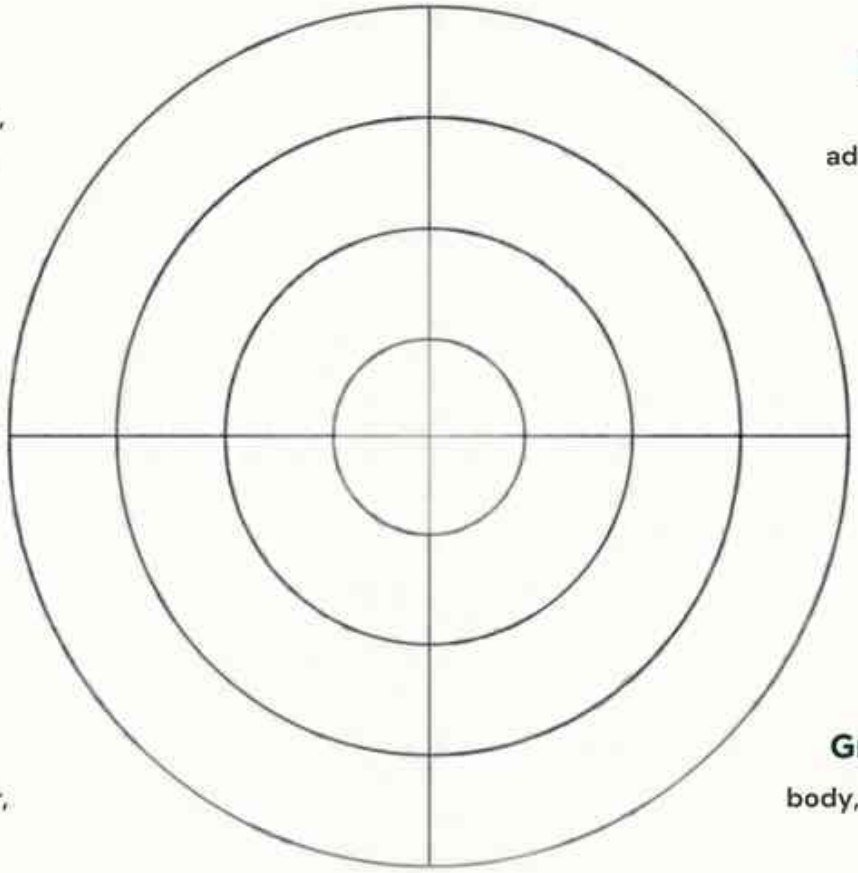
Help break goals into small steps and plan around barriers together.

Worksheet: Values Bull's-Eye

Write what matters to you in each life area. Then put an X on the target for each area: the closer to the center, the more you are living that value right now.
(Exercise developed by Tobias Lundgren; adapted from Harris, ACT Made Simple)

Work / School
career, learning, effort, creativity, teamwork

Fun / Leisure
hobbies, play, adventure, creativity



Relationships
family, friends, partner, community

Growth / Health
body, mind, spirituality, rest

What gets in the way?

Thoughts, feelings, or avoidance that pull you away from the center...

One small step toward the bull's-eye this week

Worksheet: The Choice Point

In every hard moment we have a choice: move toward who we want to be, or away from it. Away moves are not "bad," they are just unworkable in the long run. (Choice Point: Ciarrochi, Bailey & Harris)

AWAY Moves

acting on autopilot when hooked

The Situation & Hooks

difficult thoughts, feelings, urges

The situation

My hooks (thoughts/feelings)

TOWARD Moves

acting on values

Away moves I tend to make

Toward moves I could make

Unhooking skill I will use

e.g., Drop Anchor, "I'm having the thought...", Notice-Name-Make-Room

Worksheet: Committed Action Plan

Turn a value into a step you will actually take. Small and specific beats big and vague.
(Structure adapted from Harris's SMART goals and Willingness & Action Plan, ACT Made Simple)

The value I am moving toward

My goal (SMART)

When & where I'll do it

Step-by-Step

Small step	By when	Done ✓

Feelings I'm willing to have

Likely barriers

How I'll respond (DARE)

My support person

Willingness (0–10)

Reflection after the week
What did I learn? What did I notice? What is my next step?

Phases of Practice

The six processes are all connected, but many people find it helpful to build skills in a gentle progression. Circling back is normal and expected.

PHASE 1

Present & Grounded

Drop Anchor, 5-4-3-2-1, mindful breathing.
Build the ability to steady yourself.
Goal: "I can come back to now."

PHASE 2

Clarify Values

Card sort, Bull's-Eye, 80th birthday.
Know your "why" so discomfort has a purpose.
Goal: "I know what matters."

PHASE 3

Unhook & Open Up

Defusion and acceptance: Leaves on a Stream, "I'm having the thought...", Notice-Name-Make-Room, dropping the rope. Goal: "I can have this and still choose."

PHASE 4

Observing Self

Sky & weather, chessboard, more than a label.
Loosen rigid stories about who you are.
Goal: "I am bigger than my thoughts."

PHASE 5

Committed Action & Willingness Exposures

Choice Point, SMART goals, tiny-steps ladder.
Practice values-guided approach to feared situations (used with exposure work for anxiety, OCD, or trauma).
Goal: "I move toward what matters, feelings and all."

PHASE 6

Maintain & Recommit

Weekly check-ins, barrier planning, self-compassion after slips.
Goal: "I can always begin again."



ACT & Exposure

In ACT-informed exposure, the goal is not to make anxiety go away, but to practice flexibility: being willing to feel fear while moving toward values. (Bethay, Weinstein & Stubb's, ACT Strategies Guide)



ACT at Home

Do

- Validate first: "That sounds really hard."
- Name your own feelings out loud.
- Praise willingness and effort.
- Ask: "Is that a toward or away move?"
- Practice skills together, not just "assign" them.

Try Not To

- Argue with thoughts ("That's silly!").
- Rescue loved ones from all discomfort.
- Impose your values as theirs.
- Shame setbacks; commitment is the skill.

Quick Family Scripts

- "Your mind is telling you a scary story. What would you do if it were just a story?"
- "Can you take the worry along with you, like a passenger?"
- "What matters to you about this?"
- "Let's drop anchor together."

Daily ACT Check-In

- **Open:** What am I feeling? Can I make room?
- **Aware:** Where am I? What is happening now?
- **Engaged:** One toward move today?

When to Reach Out for More Support

If thoughts of self-harm, intense panic, or daily life being significantly disrupted show up, contact a licensed mental health professional. In a crisis, call or text **988** (Suicide & Crisis Lifeline) or call **911**.

Sources & Credits

Exercises are summarized and adapted in our own words for educational use. Bethay, J. S., Weinstein, J. H., & Stubbs, W. Acceptance and Commitment Therapy Strategies Guide for Anxiety and Trauma-Related Problems in Living. · Harris, R. (2009/2019). ACT Made Simple. New Harbinger. · Harris, R. (2013). Brief Case Conceptualization Worksheet. Getting Unstuck in ACT. · Hayes, S. C., Strosahl, K. D., & Wilson, K. G. (1999, 2012). Acceptance and Commitment Therapy. Guilford. · Choice Point: Ciarrochi, Bailey & Harris (2014). · Bull's-Eye: Lundgren et al.

This guide is for education and does not replace individualized therapy.